

EXPERIMENTS IN SPACE

GROWING PLANTS IN LOW GRAVITY

On the International Space Station (ISS), astronauts carry out many different experiments in a lab that's out of this world! These include examining how fire behaves in low gravity, studying radiation from stars, and growing plants in space. Plants not only supply fresh food, but are also great for the mental well-being of the astronauts. However, low gravity can affect the growth of plants. If astronauts used soil, this would float away, so instead they keep the plants' roots in protective pouches filled with nutrients.

EDIBLE GREENS

While much of the food on the ISS comes in pouches from Earth, fresh vegetables have begun to be grown on board. Future space exploration may take humans to farther-off places such as Mars, so it will be essential for astronauts to grow their own food.



PLANT GROWTH

To grow in space, plants need the same things as on Earth. The most important of these are water, minerals, and light. On the ISS, light comes from lamps. The heat from these lamps provides the right temperature for growth. Nutrients that are usually found in the soil are added to the water.

